Module 9: Classics in Sociology — the Institutionalist Legacy (Durkheim & Weber, 1890–2020)

Political & Economic Thought — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Readings: Andersen & Kaspersen (eds), *Classical and Modern Social Theory* (Blackwell, 2000), **ch. 5 (Durkheim) & ch. 6 (Weber), pp. 57–95** · Émile **Durkheim**, "What is a social fact?" (1895), from *The Rules of Sociological Method*, **pp. 26–30** · Max **Weber**, "Author's Introduction" to *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* (1904/1930), **pp. 13–31**. *(Lecturer: Benjamin Ask Popp-Madsen — deck "Émile Durkheim & Max Weber.")*

Theme of the module. As industrial modernity remade society, a **new science — sociology** — emerged to answer two questions: **how is society held together, and how can it be studied scientifically?** The two founders give **opposite** answers. **Durkheim** says society is an **external reality of "social facts"** that **constrain** individuals from the outside; study it **like a natural science** (positivism), and you find it is held together by **solidarity** (functionalism). **Weber** says society is the **product of individual actions** that carry **meaning**; study it by **understanding (Verstehen)** those meanings through **ideal types**, and you find modernity's hallmark is **rationalisation.** Their clash over capitalism is also a reply to **Marx**: for Weber, it was **religious ideas** (the Protestant ethic), not just the material base, that drove capitalism into being.

> ★ **The heart of the module — two founders, two opposite methods.**
> • **Durkheim — structure first (holism / positivism):** society is a reality *sui generis*, made of **social facts** — ways of acting/thinking that are **external** to the individual and **exercise constraint.** Study them **like things** (natural-science method, statistics). Society coheres through **solidarity**; each institution has a **function** for the whole. *Supra-individual order comes first; individual action is its effect.*
> • **Weber — meaning first (individualism / interpretivism):** society is the **product of individuals' meaningful actions.** Study it by **Verstehen** (understanding their motives), using **ideal types.** Modernity's signature is **rationalisation** — the spread of calculable, goal-oriented rationality to every sphere (law, bureaucracy, science, economy).
> • **On capitalism (vs Marx):** Weber argues the **Protestant (Calvinist) ethic** — not merely economic forces — produced the "**spirit of capitalism.**" *Ideas moved the base*, reversing Marx's arrow. But the outcome is bleak: once the religious meaning drains away, we are left in the "**iron cage**" of **disenchanted** rationality.

Red thread: *(1) Why did sociology appear when it did? (2) What holds modern society together — and how do we study it: as external structure (Durkheim) or as meaningful action (Weber)? (3) Where did capitalism really come from — the material base (Marx) or religious ideas (Weber)?*

Key concepts to apply: *the emergence of sociology · "how is society held together & studied?"* · **Durkheim:** *science of society · beyond methodological individualism · structuralism · collectivism ·* ***positivism*** *·* ***social fact*** *(external + constraining) ·* ***social currents*** *· types of constraint (material · structural · moral/normative · cultural/cognitive) · socialisation ·* ***functionalism*** *(society as organism; function = social cohesion) ·* ***mechanical vs organic solidarity*** *·*

the division of labour · Suicide as a social fact. · **Weber:** *interpretivism · methodological individualism ·* ***Verstehen*** *·* ***ideal types*** *· the four types of action (traditional · affectual · value-rational · instrumental-rational) · the uniqueness of Western* ***rationalism*** *·* ***the Protestant ethic & the spirit of capitalism*** *· predestination · the "calling" · worldly asceticism ·* ***rationalisation*** *·* ***disenchantment*** *· the* ***iron cage****.* · *(legacy) institutions = formal rules (Weberian) + informal norms (Durkheimian).*

The emergence of sociology

Core: sociology is born when "**society**" **itself becomes a problem** — the industrial, post-revolutionary world is a *new kind of reality* that the older disciplines (economics, philosophy, history) cannot fully grasp.

- The modern revolutions and industrial capitalism dissolved the old order (village, guild, estate, fixed religion) and produced a **new social reality** — urban, mobile, individualist, secularising.
- That reality poses the founding question: "**How is society held together, and how can it be studied?**" Sociology is the discipline that takes "**the social**" itself as its object.
- **Different from Marx.** Where Marx reduces society to **economic class struggle**, Durkheim and Weber insist "the social" has **its own logic** — norms and solidarity (Durkheim), or meaning and rationality (Weber) — not reducible to the economic base. *(And on capitalism specifically, Weber will argue the opposite of Marx — see §Protestant ethic.)*

Durkheim's sociological project

Core: Émile Durkheim (**1857–1917**) wanted to make sociology a **real science** with an object all its own — and that object is **society as a reality above the individual.**

- **A science of society:** find **general social laws, structures and connections**, modelled on the **natural sciences.** Methodology = **structuralism · collectivism · positivism.**
- **Beyond methodological individualism:** human beings are **part of and formed by social structures.** You cannot explain society by summing up individuals; you must give **supra-individual explanations** — the structure comes **first**, individual action is its **effect.**
- "**The social**"**:** his key words are **organicism, cohesion, stability** — how society holds together.
- **Modern solidarity is still possible** — but, in modern society, for **different reasons** than in traditional society (see solidarity).
- **Major works:** *The Division of Labour in Society* (1893), *The Rules of Sociological Method* (1895), *Suicide* (1897), *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912).

★ Social facts

Core: Durkheim's foundational concept. A **social fact** is a way of acting/thinking that is **external** to the individual and **exercises constraint** on them — it must be studied **like a thing** (an object), the hallmark

of his **positivism.**

The definition

> "A **social fact** is every way of acting, fixed or not, capable of exercising on the individual an **external constraint**; or again, every way of acting which is **general** throughout a given society, while at the same time **existing in its own right independent of its individual manifestations.**" *(Durkheim, 1895: 30)*

Two defining properties

1. **Externality** — social facts exist **outside** me and **before** me. "The church-member finds the beliefs and practices of his religious life **ready-made at birth**." I did not create law, language, currency, or custom — I **inherited** them.
2. **Constraint / coercion** — they **impose themselves** on me whether I like it or not. The proof is **resistance**: break the **law** and it reacts to punish you; flout **moral maxims** and the public conscience penalises you; ignore **convention** (dress, custom) and you meet **ridicule and social isolation.** "*The air is no less heavy because we do not detect its weight*" — the constraint operates even when we comply willingly.

Why it is sociology's *own* object

Social facts are **not biological** (they are representations and actions, not physiology) and **not psychological** (they exist **outside** any single individual consciousness). They are a **new category** — and *only* sociology studies them.

- **Examples (Durkheim's own):** duties as brother/husband/citizen · **contracts** · **law & custom** · **religious** beliefs & practices · **language** (a system of signs) · the **currency** I pay with · commercial practices.
- **Social currents** — social facts *without* a fixed, crystallised form: the great crowd movements of **enthusiasm, indignation, pity.** They come from outside and "**carry us away in spite of ourselves**" — a gathering of harmless individuals can be "drawn into acts of atrocity." Also the drifting **currents of opinion**.
- "**Ways of existing" (morphological facts)** — housing types, the channels of migration and commerce, political organisation — are just **crystallised "ways of acting."** "*If the population crowds into our cities instead of scattering… this is due to a… collective drive that imposes this concentration upon the individuals.*"

Social constraint & its types

Core: constraint is **not** a restraint on liberty to be resented — it is **socialisation**, the very basis of stable social life. "Supra-individual order is primary; individual actions and ideas are an effect of this structure."

Type of constraint	What it is
Material	production, living conditions, technology, communication, transportation
Structural	the hierarchical patterns of society
Moral / normative	socialisation; the sense of respect and obligation (norms we feel *obliged* to follow)
Cultural / cognitive	the ideas, concepts and **language** through which we even think

→ *In plain terms:* we are **socialised into** living in society — constraint is everywhere, and it is what makes shared, stable social life possible at all. *(This is the opposite of the liberal "individual-first" picture: for Durkheim the group shapes the individual, not the reverse.)*

Functionalism & solidarity — what holds society together?

Core: Durkheim explains society like a **biologist explains an organism** — by the **function** each part plays in sustaining the whole. The thing it sustains is **solidarity.**

Functionalism

- **Society as an organism:** each component (family, religion, law, the economy) has a **function** — a contribution to the **maintenance of the whole.**
- To explain a social phenomenon is to state its **function**: e.g. **the function of religion is to produce social cohesion** (not to be literally true). Sociology asks: *what does this phenomenon do for social integration?*

Mechanical vs organic solidarity (*The Division of Labour*, 1893)

Durkheim's answer to "what holds society together?" — and how it **changes** with modernity:

	Mechanical solidarity (traditional)	Organic solidarity (modern)
Based on	**likeness** — everyone shares beliefs, work, a strong **collective conscience**	**difference** — an advanced **division of labour** makes people **interdependent**
Bond	we are the same	we **need** each other (the baker needs the farmer needs the doctor…)
Typical law	**repressive** (punishes offences against the shared conscience)	**restitutive** (restores broken contracts/relations)

→ The reassurance against the "social question": modernity does **not** doom us to anomie — it generates a **new** kind of glue, **organic** solidarity, out of the very division of labour that seemed to be tearing society apart.

Suicide — the showcase

Suicide (1897) is the demonstration case: even the **most intensely "individual" act** turns out to have **social causes. Suicide rates are stable social facts** — remarkably constant within a group, varying *between* groups (by religion, marital status, etc.) according to how strongly individuals are **integrated into and regulated by** society. → *Illustrates:* social facts explain what looks purely personal; the method (statistics on rates) is positivism in action.

Weber's project & the uniqueness of the West

Core: Max Weber (**1864–1920**) asks a historical question: **why did *modern, rational* society — and rational capitalism — arise only in the West?** His whole sociology is built to answer it from the **meaningful action of individuals.**

- **The guiding questions:** *Why did modernity evolve as it did? What is distinctive about modern Western society? Why did capitalism arise in the West, and what role did **religious ideas** play?*
- **The uniqueness of Western rationalism** (Weber's "Author's Introduction"): only in the **Occident** did a whole family of phenomena develop a **rational, systematic** form claiming **universal** validity —
  - **science** (systematic, mathematical, experimental proof — others had empirical knowledge but not *rational method*);
  - **rational music** (harmony, counterpoint), **rational architecture** (the Gothic vault), the **printed press & universities**;
  - the **rational state** (written constitution, **rational law**, administration by **trained officials / bureaucracy**);
  - and above all **rational capitalism.**
- **Capitalism's "spirit" is the puzzle, not greed.** The mere *impulse to acquisition* "has nothing to do with capitalism" — it exists "among waiters, physicians, coachmen, artists, prostitutes... at all times and in all countries." Capitalism is the **rational tempering** of that impulse: the **pursuit of profit by means of continuous, rational, calculating enterprise.** What is uniquely Western is the **rational organisation of (formally) free labour**, the separation of **business from household**, and **rational book-keeping.**
- **Method: methodological individualism + interpretive** social science — start from **human action and its meaning** (the opposite of Durkheim's structure-first holism).

★ Verstehen & ideal types

Core: Weber's method. To explain society you must **understand (Verstehen)** the **meaning** actors give their own action — and to compare and analyse, you build **ideal types.**

- **Verstehen (understanding):** sociology interprets **why people do what they do** — the subjective meaning of action — rather than reading social facts off from the outside. *(Scientific model: the **humanities**, not the natural sciences.)*

- **Ideal types:** deliberately **one-sided, purified analytical constructions** (no real case matches exactly) used as a **yardstick** to compare and classify messy reality — e.g. the ideal types of **rationality** and of **action**:

Type of action	Driven by
Traditional	habit, custom ("we've always done it this way")
Affectual	emotion/affection
Value-rational	commitment to a value for its own sake (honour, duty, faith)
Instrumental-rational	calculated, goal-oriented means–ends reasoning

→ Weber's central historical claim: it is **instrumental rationality** that progressively **conquers every sphere** of modern Western life (economy, law, state, science, even music) — the process he calls **rationalisation.**

★ The Protestant Ethic & the spirit of capitalism

Core: Weber's most famous argument — and his reply to Marx. Capitalism is not just an economic system but a **rational-ethical *way of life***, and its "spirit" was **unintentionally** produced by **Calvinist Protestantism.**

What the "spirit of capitalism" is

A moral valorisation of "**restless, continuous, systematic work**" and the disciplined pursuit of profit **as a duty** — captured by **Benjamin Franklin**: "*Remember that **time is money**... Remember that **credit is money**... money is of a **prolific, generating nature**.*" Profit is sought **not** to enjoy it but as an **end in itself**, a sign of virtue.

What Weber argues *against* (three rival explanations)

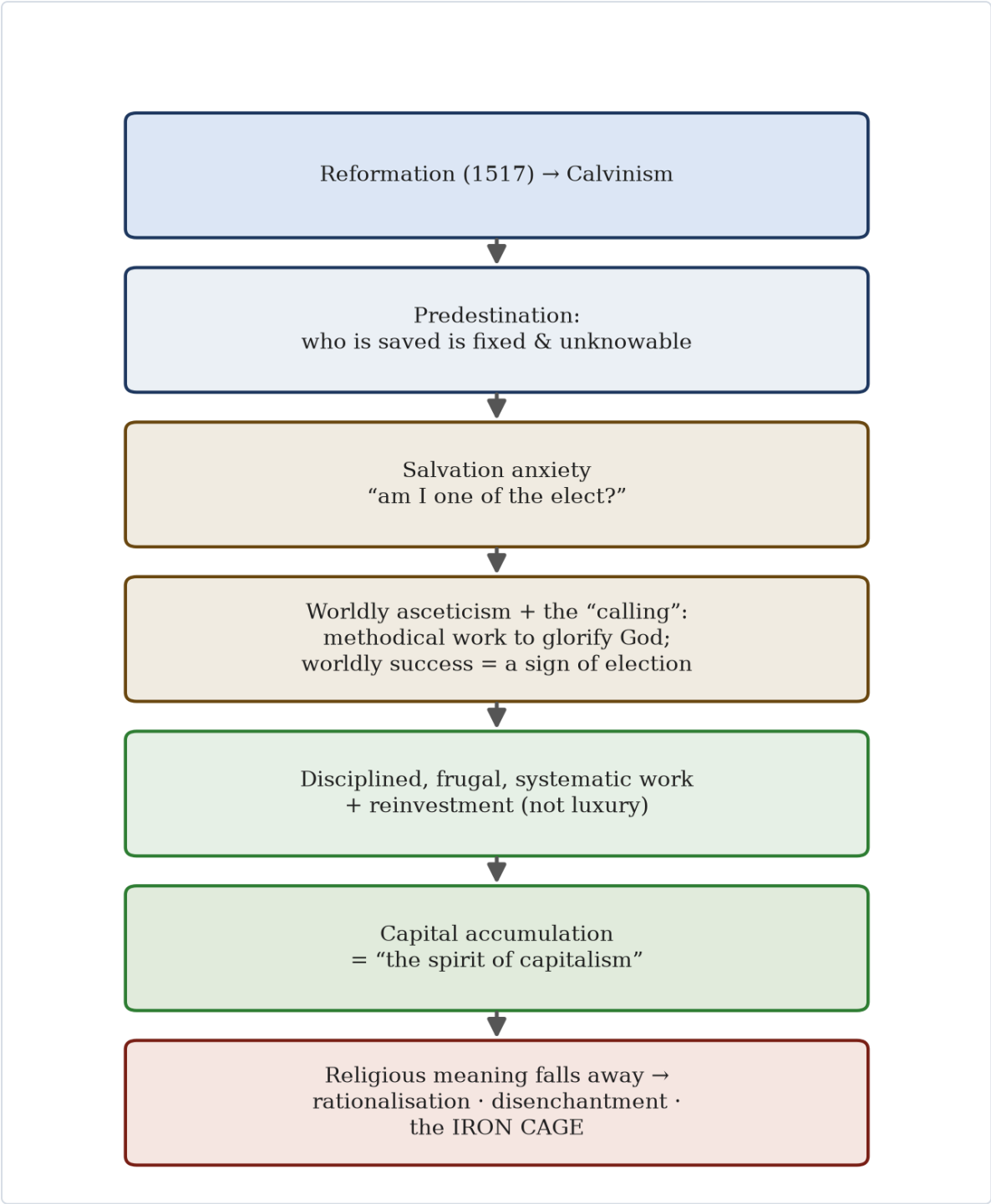
Rival explanation	Weber's objection
Secularisation did it	capitalism's spirit was **religious** in origin, not a product of losing religion
Utilitarian (people just maximise utility)	the early capitalist's **ascetic self-denial** is irrational by pure utility — he *won't* enjoy his wealth
Materialist / Marx (economic forces alone)	**ideas** (religious ethics) were an **independent cause**, not a mere reflection of the base

The obstacles the spirit had to overcome

Traditionalism — "belief in **fate**," the view that "striving for profit is immoral," the **prohibition of interest**, "belief in **magic**" over science, work as a mere necessity — plus the **extravagant, non-**

investing lifestyle of the nobility. Modern capitalism needed a **broadly shared belief system** that made disciplined accumulation feel *righteous*.

The causal chain (via Calvinism)



How to read it.

- The **Reformation (1517)** breaks the Catholic model (priest/church as the link to God, forgiveness by indulgence); **Lutheranism** makes the God–individual relation **direct**; **Calvinism** adds **predestination** — who is saved is **fixed in advance and unknowable.**
- That doctrine produces unbearable **salvation anxiety** ("am I one of the elect?"). The psychological relief: treat **worldly success in a "calling"** as a **sign** of being chosen — so one works **methodically**

and relentlessly to glorify God.

- "**Waste of time is a deadly sin**"; luxury and idleness are forbidden → the godly route is **disciplined work + frugality + reinvestment** (not consumption) → **capital accumulates.** The wealthy reinvest; workers give **full commitment to their specialist position** (Weber's twist on the division of labour: *stay in your calling*).
- The decisive quote: "*the religious valuation of **restless, continuous, systematic work** in a worldly calling... must have been the most powerful conceivable lever for the expansion of... the **spirit of capitalism**.*" (Protestant Ethic, p. 172)

Rationalisation, disenchantment & the iron cage

Core: the sting in the tail — Weber's **diagnosis of modernity** as a "double-edged sword." Rationality liberated us from magic and superstition, but then **trapped** us.

- **The religious scaffolding falls away.** Once capitalism is up and running, the **pursuit of wealth and work is stripped of its religious/ethical meaning** — the Puritan *chose* his calling; modern man is simply *born into* "this mechanism" and compelled by it "with irresistible force... perhaps until the last ton of fossilised coal is burnt." (p. 181)
- **Disenchantment (*Entzauberung*):** "**magic has gone from the world.**" A rationalised, calculable world has no room for mystery, the sacred, or wonder.
- **The iron cage:** the rational economic order has become a **cage** that constrains everyone — the dark mirror-image of Durkheim's benign "constraint." Rationalisation is **double-edged**: efficient and free *and* meaningless and imprisoning. *(This pessimism is Weber's lasting mood — modernity as progress **and** loss.)*

★ Durkheim vs Weber (and vs Marx)

Core: the two founders are **mirror opposites** on every methodological axis — and together they define the "**institutionalist legacy**" still used to study organisations today.

	Durkheim	Weber
What is society?	an **external reality** to individuals	the **product of individual actors**
What are individuals?	agents who **internalise & reproduce** society's norms	agents with **intentions & interests** guiding their action
What is sociology?	the science of **social facts**	the science of **social actions**
Method	**explain** social facts; reject individualism/subjectivity	**Verstehen** of motives; reconstruct the **meaning** of action
Scientific model	the **natural sciences**	the **humanities**
Tools	**statistics**	**ideal types**
Objects of research	general **social laws & functions**	individual **motivations**, a plurality of causes

…and vs Marx (on capitalism)

- **Marx:** capitalism arises from the **material base** — forces & relations of production; ideas/religion are **superstructure** (Module 8).
- **Weber: religious ideas** (the Protestant ethic) were an **independent cause** of capitalism — *ideas moved the base.* The **reverse** of Marx's arrow.
- **Durkheim:** neither class nor ideas alone — society is a **reality in its own right**, held together by **solidarity**, with each institution serving a **function.**

The legacy (the module's "so what")

Durkheim and Weber are the ancestors of how we study **institutions and organisations** today, as the interplay of:

- **formal rules** — laws, written regulations (the **Weberian**, rational-bureaucratic side), and
- **informal order** — norms, traditions, values, ideology, religion (the **Durkheimian**, social-fact side).

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Social fact	a way of acting/thinking **external** to the individual and exercising **constraint**
Social constraint	the (material/structural/moral/cognitive) pressure of society on the individual = socialisation
Social currents	social facts without fixed form (crowd emotions, currents of opinion)
Positivism	study society **like a natural object**, seeking general laws
Functionalism	explain a phenomenon by its **function** for the maintenance of the whole
Collective conscience	the shared beliefs/sentiments binding a traditional society
Mechanical solidarity	cohesion through **likeness** (traditional society; repressive law)
Organic solidarity	cohesion through **interdependence** via the division of labour (modern; restitutive law)
Verstehen	interpretive **understanding** of the meaning of social action
Ideal type	a purified analytical construct used to compare/classify reality
Instrumental rationality	calculated, goal-oriented means–ends action
Rationalisation	the spread of calculable, instrumental rationality to all spheres of life
The calling	treating disciplined work in one's vocation as a religious duty
Predestination	Calvin's doctrine that salvation is fixed in advance and unknowable
Worldly asceticism	disciplined, frugal, hard-working self-denial *within* worldly life
Spirit of capitalism	the ethic valorising restless, systematic work and reinvested profit
Disenchantment	the loss of magic/mystery from a rationalised world
The iron cage	the inescapable, meaning-drained constraint of rationalised modern order

Exam pointers

- **Define a social fact** (external + constraining) and prove it with the **resistance** test and Durkheim's examples (law, language, currency, religion).
- **Explain functionalism** and the shift from **mechanical to organic solidarity** — Durkheim's reassuring answer to the "social question."
- **Contrast positivism vs Verstehen** — study society as external *things* vs *understand* meaningful action. Name the tools (**statistics vs ideal types**).

- **Run Weber's Protestant-ethic chain**: predestination → salvation anxiety → calling/worldly asceticism → reinvestment → spirit of capitalism. Name the **three rivals** he rejects.
- **State the Durkheim vs Weber vs Marx** positions on capitalism's origin — and why **Weber reverses Marx's arrow** (ideas → base).
- **Explain rationalisation, disenchantment and the iron cage** as modernity's double-edged sword.

★ Fun facts & memorable details (Module 9: Durkheim & Weber)

> The sticky bits from the sociology classics.

- "**The air is no less heavy because we do not detect its weight.**" Durkheim's image for how social constraint presses on us even when we obey happily and feel perfectly free.
- **Suicide — the most "personal" act — is a social fact.** Rates stay eerily constant within a group and differ sharply *between* groups. The most intimate decision turns out to track how integrated you are into society.
- **A crowd of harmless people can be "drawn into acts of atrocity."** Durkheim's **social currents**: emotions that come from *outside* the individuals and sweep them along — gone strange to them once the crowd disperses.
- **Weber says greed has nothing to do with capitalism.** The lust for money exists "among waiters, physicians... prostitutes... at all times." Capitalism is the *rational tempering* of that impulse — not the impulse itself.
- **Capitalism was an accident of anxiety.** No Calvinist set out to invent capitalism; they were trying to cope with not knowing if they were saved. Disciplined work + no spending = capital piled up as an unintended by-product.
- "**Time is money**" **was religious before it was financial.** Franklin's maxim distils a Puritan horror of wasted time ("waste of time is the deadliest of sins") into a business creed.
- **The iron cage.** Weber's bleak punchline: the rationality that freed us from magic now imprisons us in a meaningless mechanism — "perhaps until the last ton of fossilised coal is burnt."
- **Ideas can move the base.** Weber's quiet revolution against Marx: a *religious idea* (predestination) reshaped the whole *economic* order — the superstructure pushing the base, not the other way round.
